

SWORD v17c Variable Reference

Quick-lookup for all variables in the v17c NetCDF export files (`{region}_sword_v17c_beta.nc`).

Fill values: i4 = -9999, i8 = -9999, f8 = -9999.0

Distance Variable Conventions

SWORD contains four distance-to-outlet variables. They differ in routing method, zero-point, and measurement anchor within a reach. The table below summarizes these conventions; see “Node-Level Interpolation” for how each extends to nodes.

Variable	Routing	Reach-level anchor	Outlet value	Ghost reaches
<code>dist_out</code> (v17b)	v17b topology	upstream end of reach	<code>reach_length</code>	has value
<code>hydro_dist_out</code>	<code>rch_id_dn_main</code> chain	upstream end of reach	<code>reach_length</code>	has value
<code>dist_out_dijkstra</code>	Dijkstra shortest path	upstream end of reach	0	NULL
<code>hydro_dist_hw</code>	<code>rch_id_up_main</code> chain	downstream end of reach	headwater <code>reach_length</code>	has value

Anchor convention. For `dist_out`, `hydro_dist_out`, and `dist_out_dijkstra`, the reach-level value equals the distance from the upstream end of the reach to the outlet. Each reach’s value therefore exceeds its downstream neighbor’s value by exactly its own `reach_length`. For `hydro_dist_hw` the convention is reversed: the reach-level value equals the distance from the headwater to the downstream end of the reach, so each reach’s value exceeds its upstream neighbor’s value by exactly its own `reach_length`.

Zero-point difference. `dist_out` and `hydro_dist_out` assign the outlet reach a value equal to its `reach_length` (the upstream end is one `reach_length` from the outlet point). `dist_out_dijkstra` assigns the outlet reach a value of 0 (the outlet point itself is the reference). When comparing these variables, the offset at any reach equals the outlet’s `reach_length`.

Ghost reaches. `dist_out_dijkstra` is NULL for ghost reaches (type=6). The other three variables retain values for ghost reaches.

Node-Level Interpolation

Five v17c variables are interpolated per node using the node’s position within its parent reach. The offset from the reach’s upstream end is `reach.dist_out - node.dist_out` (where `node.dist_out` is the v17b original). For flow-corrected reaches (660), the offset direction is reversed.

Variable	Node formula	node_order=n (upstream)	node_order=1 (downstream)
hydro_dist_out	reach.hdo - offset	reach.hdo	reach.hdo - reach_length
dist_out_dijkstra	reach.dod - offset	reach.dod	reach.dod - reach_length
hydro_dist_hw	reach.hdh - reach_length + offset	reach.hdh - reach_length	reach.hdh
pathlen_hw	reach.plh - reach_length + offset	reach.plh - reach_length	reach.plh
pathlen_out	reach.plo + reach_length - offset	reach.plo + reach_length	reach.plo

For single-node reaches, the offset is `reach_length / 2` (midpoint). Three additional variables (`subnetwork_id`, `best_headwater`, `best_outlet`) are flat copies from the parent reach.

Node `dist_out` is the v17b original value, not interpolated. It serves as the positional anchor for interpolation but is not itself recomputed. At single-node outlet reaches, `node.dist_out` equals the reach-level value (not the midpoint), while `node.hydro_dist_out` uses the midpoint convention. This difference is by design: v17b `dist_out` is preserved as-is for backward compatibility.

Boundary continuity. At reach boundaries, the downstream-end node of the upstream reach and the upstream-end node of the downstream reach share identical interpolated distance values (verified gap = 0.00 m across all boundaries).

New v17c Reach Variables

Variable	NetCDF Type	Units	Fill Value	Encoding	Description
dist_out_dijkstra	float64	meters	-9999.0	utf8	Dijkstra shortest-path distance from the upstream end of the reach to any network outlet; outlet reach = 0; NULL for ghost reaches (type=6)

Variable	NetCDF Type	Units	Fill Value	Encoding	Description
hydro_dist_out	f8	meters	-9999.0		Mainstem distance from the upstream end of the reach to best_outlet via rch_id_dn_main chain; outlet reach = reach_length
hydro_dist_hw	f8	meters	-9999.0		Mainstem distance from best_headwater to the downstream end of the reach via rch_id_up_main chain; headwater reach = reach_length
rch_id_up_main	i8		-9999		Main upstream neighbor reach ID (mainstem-preferred)
rch_id_dn_main	i8		-9999		Main downstream neighbor reach ID (mainstem-preferred)
subnetwork_id	i4		-9999		Connected component ID (Pfafstetter-offset, globally unique; differs from v17b network)

Variable	NetCDF Type	Units	Fill Value	Encoding	Description
main_path_id	i8		-9999		ID of the mainstem path this reach belongs to
is_mainstem	i4		-9999	flag_values=[0,1] flag_meanings="reach is a mainstem"	Whether reach is a mainstem
best_headwater	i8		-9999		Width-prioritized upstream headwater reach ID
best_outlet	i8		-9999		Width-prioritized downstream outlet reach ID
pathlen_hw	f8	meters	-9999.0		Cumulative reach_length sum from best_headwater to the downstream end of the reach (headwater = 0, increases downstream)
pathlen_out	f8	meters	-9999.0		Cumulative reach_length sum from the upstream end of the reach to best_outlet (outlet = 0, increases upstream)
facc_quality	i4		-9999	flag_values=[1], flag_meanings="denominator"	Flow correction flag

Variable	NetCDF Type	Units	Fill Value	Encoding	Description
dl_grod_id	i8		-9999		Dam/lake GROD ID (downstream lookup)
wse_obs_p10	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE 10th percentile
wse_obs_p20	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE 20th percentile
wse_obs_p30	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE 30th percentile
wse_obs_p40	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE 40th percentile
wse_obs_p50	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE 50th percentile (median)
wse_obs_p60	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE 60th percentile
wse_obs_p70	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE 70th percentile
wse_obs_p80	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE 80th percentile
wse_obs_p90	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE 90th percentile
wse_obs_range	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE range (p90 - p10)
wse_obs_mad	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE median absolute deviation
width_obs_p10	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT width 10th percentile
width_obs_p20	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT width 20th percentile

Variable	NetCDF Type	Units	Fill Value	Encoding	Description
width_obs_p30 f8		meters	-9999.0		SWOT width 30th percentile
width_obs_p40 f8		meters	-9999.0		SWOT width 40th percentile
width_obs_p50 f8		meters	-9999.0		SWOT width 50th percentile (median)
width_obs_p60 f8		meters	-9999.0		SWOT width 60th percentile
width_obs_p70 f8		meters	-9999.0		SWOT width 70th percentile
width_obs_p80 f8		meters	-9999.0		SWOT width 80th percentile
width_obs_p90 f8		meters	-9999.0		SWOT width 90th percentile
width_obs_range f8		meters	-9999.0		SWOT width range (p90 - p10)
width_obs_mad f8		meters	-9999.0		SWOT width median absolute deviation
slope_obs_p10 f8		meters/kilometers	-9999.0		SWOT slope 10th percentile
slope_obs_p20 f8		meters/kilometers	-9999.0		SWOT slope 20th percentile
slope_obs_p30 f8		meters/kilometers	-9999.0		SWOT slope 30th percentile
slope_obs_p40 f8		meters/kilometers	-9999.0		SWOT slope 40th percentile
slope_obs_p50 f8		meters/kilometers	-9999.0		SWOT slope 50th percentile (median)

Variable	NetCDF Type	Units	Fill Value	Encoding	Description
slope_obs_p60	f8	meters/kilometers	-9999.0		SWOT slope 60th percentile
slope_obs_p70	f8	meters/kilometers	-9999.0		SWOT slope 70th percentile
slope_obs_p80	f8	meters/kilometers	-9999.0		SWOT slope 80th percentile
slope_obs_p90	f8	meters/kilometers	-9999.0		SWOT slope 90th percentile
slope_obs_range	f8	meters/kilometers	-9999.0		SWOT slope range (p90 - p10)
slope_obs_mad	f8	meters/kilometers	-9999.0		SWOT slope median absolute deviation
slope_obs_adj	f8	meters/kilometers	-9999.0		Adjusted SWOT slope (bias-corrected)
slope_obs_slope	f8		-9999.0		Slope quality F-statistic
slope_obs_reliable	boolean		-9999	BOOL->i1 (True=1, False=0)	Whether SWOT slope is reliable
slope_obs_quality	string			VARCHAR (reliable, small_negative, moderate_negative, large_negative, negative, below_ref_uncertainty, high_uncertainty, noise_high_nobs, flat_water_noise)	SWOT slope quality category
slope_obs_n	i8		-9999		Number of SWOT slope observations
slope_obs_n_passes	i8		-9999		Number of SWOT passes with slope

Variable	NetCDF Type	Units	Fill Value	Encoding	Description
slope_obs_q	i8		-9999	Integer bitfield (1=negative, 2=low_passes, 4=high_var, 8=extreme, 16=clipped)	SWOT slope quality bitfield
n_obs	i4		-9999		Total number of SWOT observations

New v17c Node Variables

Variable	NetCDF Type	Units	Fill Value	Encoding	Description
subnetwork_id	i4		-9999		Connected component ID (from parent reach)
best_headwater	i8		-9999		Width- prioritized upstream headwater reach ID
best_outlet	i8		-9999		Width- prioritized downstream outlet reach ID
pathlen_hw	f8	meters	-9999.0		Cumulative path length from headwater, interpolated by node position within reach; single-node reaches use midpoint

Variable	NetCDF Type	Units	Fill Value	Encoding	Description
pathlen_out	f8	meters	-9999.0		Cumulative path length to outlet, interpolated by node position within reach; single-node reaches use midpoint
hydro_dist_out	f8	meters	-9999.0		Mainstem distance to best_outlet, interpolated by node position within reach; single-node reaches use midpoint
hydro_dist_hw	f8	meters	-9999.0		Distance from best_headwater, interpolated by node position within reach; single-node reaches use midpoint
dist_out_dijkstra	f8	meters	-9999.0		Dijkstra shortest-path distance to outlet, interpolated by node position within reach; single-node reaches use midpoint; NULL for ghost reaches
wse_obs_p10	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE 10th percentile

Variable	NetCDF Type	Units	Fill Value	Encoding	Description
wse_obs_p20	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE 20th percentile
wse_obs_p30	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE 30th percentile
wse_obs_p40	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE 40th percentile
wse_obs_p50	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE 50th percentile (median)
wse_obs_p60	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE 60th percentile
wse_obs_p70	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE 70th percentile
wse_obs_p80	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE 80th percentile
wse_obs_p90	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE 90th percentile
wse_obs_range	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE range (p90 - p10)
wse_obs_mad	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT WSE median absolute deviation
width_obs_p10	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT width 10th percentile
width_obs_p20	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT width 20th percentile
width_obs_p30	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT width 30th percentile
width_obs_p40	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT width 40th percentile

Variable	NetCDF Type	Units	Fill Value	Encoding	Description
width_obs_p50	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT width 50th percentile (median)
width_obs_p60	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT width 60th percentile
width_obs_p70	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT width 70th percentile
width_obs_p80	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT width 80th percentile
width_obs_p90	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT width 90th percentile
width_obs_range	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT width range (p90 - p10)
width_obs_mad	f8	meters	-9999.0		SWOT width median absolute deviation
n_obs	i4		-9999		Total number of SWOT observations
facc_quality	i4		-9999	flag_values=[1], flag_meanings="denoise" in correction flag	Flow denoise correction flag

v17b Variables (unchanged)

Reaches

Variable	NetCDF Type	Units	Fill Value	Description
reach_id	i8		-9999	Reach identifier (format: CBBBB-BRRRT)
x	f8	degrees east	-9999.0	Reach centroid longitude
x_min	f8	degrees east	-9999.0	Minimum longitude of reach extent

Variable	NetCDF Type	Units	Fill Value	Description
x_max	f8	degrees east	-9999.0	Maximum longitude of reach extent
y	f8	degrees north	-9999.0	Reach centroid latitude
y_min	f8	degrees north	-9999.0	Minimum latitude of reach extent
y_max	f8	degrees north	-9999.0	Maximum latitude of reach extent
reach_length	f8	meters	-9999.0	Length of reach centerline
n_nodes	i4		-9999	Number of nodes in reach
wse	f8	meters	-9999.0	Water surface elevation (MERIT Hydro)
wse_var	f8	meters ²	-9999.0	WSE variance
width	f8	meters	-9999.0	River width (GRWL)
width_var	f8	meters ²	-9999.0	Width variance
facc	f8	km ²	-9999.0	Flow accumulation (MERIT Hydro)
n_chan_max	i4		-9999	Max number of channels at any node
n_chan_mod	i4		-9999	Modal number of channels
obstr_type	i4		-9999	Obstruction type (0=none, 1=dam, 2=lock, 3=low-head, 4=falls)
grod_id	i8		-9999	GRanD/GROD dam ID
hfalls_id	i8		-9999	High falls ID
slope	f8	meters/kilometers	-9999.0	Water surface slope from MERIT DEM

Variable	NetCDF Type	Units	Fill Value	Description
dist_out	f8	meters	-9999.0	Distance from upstream end of reach to network outlet (v17b original; outlet reach = reach_length, not 0). See “Distance Variable Conventions” for comparison with v17c distance variables
n_rch_up	i4		-9999	Number of upstream neighbor reaches
n_rch_down	i4		-9999	Number of downstream neighbor reaches
lakeflag	i4		-9999	Water body type (0=river, 1=lake, 2=canal, 3=tidal)
type	i8		-9999	Reach type (1=river, 3=lake_on_river, 4=dam, 5=unreliable, 6=ghost). Not in v17b NetCDF; added in v17c. Values from v17b database.
add_flag	i8		-9999	Manually added reach flag
swot_obs	i4		-9999	Number of expected SWOT observations per cycle
swot_obs_source	string			Source of SWOT observation data
max_width	f8	meters	-9999.0	Maximum width at any node
low_slope_flag	i4		-9999	Low slope flag

Variable	NetCDF Type	Units	Fill Value	Description
trib_flag	i4		-9999	MHV tributary enters (0=no, 1=yes, spatial proximity)
path_freq	i8		-9999	Traversal count (increases toward outlets)
path_order	i8		-9999	Path order from traversal
path_segs	i8		-9999	Unique ID for (path_order, path_freq) combination
stream_order	i4		-9999	Stream order: round(log(path_freq)) + 1
main_side	i4		-9999	Channel role (0=main, 1=side, 2=secondary outlet)
end_reach	i4		-9999	Endpoint type (0=middle, 1=headwater, 2=outlet, 3=junction)
network	i4		-9999	Connected component ID
dn_node_id	i8		-9999	Downstream boundary node ID
up_node_id	i8		-9999	Upstream boundary node ID
river_name	string			River name from GRWL
river_name_en	string			River name (English)
river_name_local	string			River name (local language)
edit_flag	string			Edit provenance tag (e.g. lake_sandwich, harp_lake)
version	string			Data version identifier

Nodes

Variable	NetCDF Type	Units	Fill Value	Description
node_id	i8		-9999	Node identifier (format: CBBBB-BRRRRNNNT)
x	f8	degrees east	-9999.0	Node longitude
y	f8	degrees north	-9999.0	Node latitude
node_length	f8	meters	-9999.0	Length of river represented by this node
node_order	i4		-9999	1-based position within reach (1=downstream, n=upstream, by dist_out)
reach_id	i8		-9999	Parent reach ID (format: CBBBB-BRRRRT)
wse	f8	meters	-9999.0	Water surface elevation (MERIT Hydro)
wse_var	f8	meters ²	-9999.0	WSE variance
width	f8	meters	-9999.0	River width (GRWL)
width_var	f8	meters ²	-9999.0	Width variance
n_chan_max	i4		-9999	Max number of channels
n_chan_mod	i4		-9999	Modal number of channels
obstr_type	i4		-9999	Obstruction type
grod_id	i8		-9999	GRanD/GROD dam ID
hfalls_id	i8		-9999	High falls ID
dist_out	f8	meters	-9999.0	Distance to network outlet (v17b original, not interpolated; serves as positional anchor for v17c node interpolation). At single-node reaches, equals the reach-level value (not midpoint)

Variable	NetCDF Type	Units	Fill Value	Description
wth_coef	f8		-9999.0	Width coefficient
ext_dist_coef	f8		-9999.0	Extraction distance coefficient
facc	f8	km ²	-9999.0	Flow accumulation (MERIT Hydro)
lakeflag	i8		-9999	Water body type (0=river, 1=lake, 2=canal, 3=tidal)
max_width	f8	meters	-9999.0	Maximum width
meander_length	f8		-9999.0	Meander wavelength
sinuosity	f8		-9999.0	Channel sinuosity
manual_add	i4		-9999	Manually added node flag
trib_flag	i4		-9999	MHV tributary enters (0=no, 1=yes)
path_freq	i8		-9999	Traversal count
path_order	i8		-9999	Path order
path_segs	i8		-9999	Path segment ID
stream_order	i4		-9999	Stream order
main_side	i4		-9999	Channel role (0=main, 1=side, 2=secondary outlet)
end_reach	i4		-9999	Endpoint type (0=middle, 1=headwater, 2=outlet, 3=junction)
network	i4		-9999	Connected component ID
add_flag	i8		-9999	Manually added node flag
river_name	string			River name
edit_flag	string			Edit provenance tag (e.g. lake_sandwich, harp_lake)
version	string			Data version identifier

Multi-dimensional Arrays

Variable	Group	Shape	Type	Description
cl_id_min	reaches	[num_reaches]	i8	Minimum centerline ID bounding this reach
cl_id_max	reaches	[num_reaches]	i8	Maximum centerline ID bounding this reach
rch_id_up	reaches	[4, num_reaches]	i8	Up to 4 upstream neighbor reach IDs
rch_id_dn	reaches	[4, num_reaches]	i8	Up to 4 downstream neighbor reach IDs
iceflag	reaches	[366, num_reaches]	i4	Daily ice presence flag (Julian day 1-366)
swot_orbits	reaches	[75, num_reaches]	i8	SWOT orbit IDs that observe this reach
cl_id_min	nodes	[num_nodes]	i8	Minimum centerline ID bounding this node
cl_id_max	nodes	[num_nodes]	i8	Maximum centerline ID bounding this node
cl_id	centerlines	[num_points]	i8	Centerline point ID
x	centerlines	[num_points]	f8	Centerline point longitude (degrees east)
y	centerlines	[num_points]	f8	Centerline point latitude (degrees north)
reach_id	centerlines	[num_points]	i8	Parent reach ID for this centerline point
node_id	centerlines	[num_points]	i8	Parent node ID for this centerline point

Variable	Group	Shape	Type	Description
version	centerlines	[num_points]	string	Data version identifier

Subgroups (copied from v17b)

Subgroup	Parent	Description
reaches/area_fits	reaches	Area-based rating curve fit coefficients
reaches/discharge_models	reaches	Discharge model parameters (organized by constraint/model)